The global state state of digital history: Establishing data culture(s) in uncertain times

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The panel session conceives of digital history as facing specific challenges beyond the larger context of the digital humanities. Firstly, we have arrived at the post-digital moment, in which the distinction between analogue and digital has lost conceptual and analytical value. Social processes, the human cultural record, and our academic fields have been *datafied*, by which we mean an epistemic shift towards a new status quo in which all social processes are always already algorithmically mediated through networked information technologies. This seismic shift towards *algorithmic cultures* (Roberge / Seyfert 2016; Hallinan / Striphas 2014) and the *epoch of computationability* (Berry 2011; Dobson 2019) requires computational methods to make historical arguments. Put differently, we will have to quickly adapt to this new environment—whose ramifications we do not yet fully understand—or else lose relevance and credibility as historians. Thus, we believe that the target audience of digital history is first and foremost the larger history profession for whom we can act as intermediaries at the contact zone with digital and computational humanities. Secondly, we consider the developments around Large Language Models (LLMs) and, more generally, generative AI a singularity, questioning the very foundations of our discipline. We have arrived at a point in time, where any narrative about events past, present or future can be supported with an infinite number of absolutely plausible and consistent textual, visual, and aural sources. Records of events that never happened can be produced with decreasing effort and absolutely no technical proof of forgery—for the time being such records are themselves mostly digital, but generating material evidence is, to the largest part, only restricted by their production costs. Thirdly, it is our conviction that history with its tradition of source criticism and as one of the core disciplines of humanities curricula is of imminent social importance. A renewed history grounded in a vivid data culture could imbue societies with the necessary epistemic knowledge, forensic skills, and data literacy. Yet, history is declining as an institutionalised discipline—with decades of cuts to departments and programmes and the falling numbers of students and graduates to match.

Considering these three challenges, we strongly believe that we need to build a new and resilient *data culture* across all disciplinary (and social) domains. Such a *data culture* would help us to address the new episteme through a theoretically-grounded understanding of the fundamental epistemological and hermeneutical affordances of the post-digital moment; through developing the necessary quotidian practices, skill sets, and disciplinary protocols; and through negotiating new understandings of history as a discipline of societal and cultural relevance.

These challenges are global, even though they are compounded by other planetary crises and injustices the negative consequences of which are disproportionately borne by the societies of the Global South. The panel aims at focusing the challenges and formulating strategies (or often-times rather tactics) to build and foster the necessary data culture(s) with colleagues from around the globe in order to tease out the fundamental challenges to digital history through a plurality of local experiences and voices. We do not, however,

claim any representativeness beyond the specific context of individual participants.

Towards a Digital-First History of the September 11th Attacks: Opportunities and Challenges

Ian Milligan

The September 11th, 2001 attacks have been extensively studied, yet histories of this transformative moment almost entirely overlook the digital traces left by everyday people online: discussion boards, emails, Flash games, early blogs, newsgroups, and list-servs, to name only a few. While considerable effort was expended to create these archives, which offer unparalleled insights into how individuals responded online, they are almost never cited or used. This is primarily due to the complexities of the platforms and the amount of digital work necessary to use these collections. I am writing a digital-first social history of the September 11th attacks, demonstrating how computational methods can richly add to this story.

In my contribution, I will reflect on this project as a cautionary tale for digital history and the humanities more generally. The data-first nature of many modern archives, coupled with historians' limited ability to be trained in and to work with computational methods, risks excluding such vital archives from historiographical conversations. These are increasingly important skills, arriving at just the moment that history departments are most under attack. Compounding these challenges, the rise of generative AI calls into the question the trustworthiness of user-deposited (both content and metadata!) archives, raising significant questions. These archives operate on trust. The potential for AI, or other malign actors, to generate plausible but false narratives – operating on cross-links to create context around fake documents – poses additional and significant epistemological questions for digital historians.

Julianne Nyhan and Andrew Flinn

This contribution will explore ongoing work to theorise, build and critically engage with the potentials and dangers of understanding digital oral history as a 'data culture', focusing especially on an exploration of the potential epistemic costs and gains to the tenets and ethical underpinnings of oral history that may follow. For the last 25 years oral history recordings have been created and preserved digitally and large-scale retro-digitisation programmes have made hard to access pre-digital oral histories available to researchers. Despite this, a digital paradigmatic shift in oral history (Thomson 2007) has mainly been seen in the creation, management and online dissemination of interviews rather than in their digitally-mediated analysis. This has begun to change recently with researchers (e.g. Salah et al. 2021; Pessanha / Salah 2021) employing computational and digital humanities approaches and tools in oral history research. The "Multimodal Digital Oral History turn" (MDOH) that we have been calling for in the field of oral history (Smyth et al. 2023) proposes to recalibrate the historic pre-eminence of the oral history transcript through an active engagement with all the oral, aural, sonic and textual affordances of both retro-digitised and born digital oral history collections, in all their modalities, transcript, sound, waveform and metadata. Moreover, it calls for a re-orientation of the digital from passive to generative and self-reflexive in the human-machine study of spoken word recordings. Drawing on our ongoing research, will exemplify a MDOH approach by using the case of laughter and other non-verbal / paralinguistic markers of hesitation and uncertainty to analyse oral history at the level of the spectrogram or wave form as well as close listening and readings of the recording and the transcripts (including AI created transcripts) with text analysis and other methods. Overall this paper will report on our ongoing research into the new possibilities for studying the manifestation of memory and the meaning-making process in oral history that arise in oral history data culture s.

Digitizing Semi-Peripheral Histories: Challenges and Opportunities in Korean Historical Records

Min-Woo Lee

Interest in digital history in South Korea is a relatively recent phenomenon. Nonetheless, Korean historians have long engaged in the digitization of the nation's historical records, which reflect significant linguistic and cultural diversity. From the Common Era to the 19th century, records were predominantly written in classical Chinese. During Japanese colonial rule in the early 20th century, Japanese scripts and language became dominant. Following liberation, Hangul, Korea's indigenous script developed in the 15th century, emerged as the primary medium for historical re-

cords. Furthermore, the Cold War era introduced English and Russian into the historical landscape due to the influence of the United States and the Soviet Union.

These linguistic complexities, shaped by historical and political contexts, have compartmentalized research within Korean historiography by period and script. The digitization of historical records and advancements in digital technologies have provided both opportunities and challenges. Automated translation and data mining have begun to overcome linguistic barriers, enabling cross-period analyses. However, the growing focus on modern records in Hangul and English, which are easier to digitize and analyse, risks marginalizing premodern histories written in classical Chinese.

My contribution examines the efforts of Korean historians in digitizing historical records and the implications of digital tools in research. It explores how the digitization process pursued by various history-related institutions in Korea overcomes the challenges posed by fragmented linguistic histories. This effort can illuminate new insights into the experiences of East Asia's medieval, colonial, and Cold War periods.

Reinventing History?

Torsten Hiltmann and Till Grallert

This contribution discusses current approaches in Germany, in the context of the NFDI4Memory consortium, to address and accompany the ongoing digital transformation of historical scholarship. By contextualizing this process within the broader development of the discipline and its evolving relationship with *digitality*, ask whether we should consider the current situation as a singular moment of fundamental change or part of a more gradual progression. Ultimately we ask to what extent change is actually necessary to ensure that historical scholarship remains relevant and future-proof in a rapidly changing world. These questions will be explored in three interrelated dimensions: theory, method, and practice: Does the central role of modelling and formalization require a revised theory of historical knowledge and its production? Do computational methods, including generative AI with its transformative potential, require a more substantial rethinking of the role of methodology in historical research? And finally, do we need to reevaluate the process of data production, especially the process of data modelling, since it requires the most domain knowledge and should therefore be placed at the center of our craft, giving much more prominence to the development and publication of guidelines as the foundation of future historical work?

Answers to these questions are far from certain and depend on the specific affordances of any concrete historian's work. The point, however, is to expand participation in this vital discussion to the larger field of historical research—where many colleagues still cling to past modes of scholarship— and to, thus, contribute to the necessary (re)integration of the methods and discourses of digital humanities into the humanities themselves.

Informal digital history? Investigating institutions, archives, and practices of digital history in Latin America

Ian Marino

I nformality has increasingly been employed to characterize various dimensions of economic, political, and social life globally in the 21st century. It encapsulates precarious employment and market transactions under the expansion of neoliberalism and activism forms on the internet. Although the wide applicability of informality underlines both its semantic richness and its vagueness, it often reflects perceived shifts in processes and structures across numerous sectors, commonly correlated with digital transformations (seen as catalysts for the destabilization of formal processes in favour of informal arrangements).

My contribution examines the intersections of the idea of informality with digital history, focusing particularly on its implications in Latin America. Thanks to the integration of data science and computational strategies, the field of digital history is marked by increasing methodological rigour. Yet, we can also observe elements of informality, fluidity, and methodological heterodoxy. I argue that the development of an "informal digital history" can be understood through global inequalities and the fragility of academic structures in peripheral regions.

My input statement covers several dimensions of digital history in Latin America, questioning the influence and significance of informality concerning the institutionalization of digital history labs, online work modalities, the academic use of social media, and the creation of digital archives. Utilizing mixed methodologies including digital ethnography, digital hermeneutics, online surveys, and oral history, this study aims to provide a comprehensive depiction of a frequently overlooked aspect of digital history, not only broadening

its understanding but also dialoguing with broader informality narratives observed across other scholarly and practical domains.

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